Fare Free Pilots On MBTA Bus Routes 111, 104, 455 to Provide Equitable Transit Within Underserved Communities Around Boston

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The MBTA provides vital transportation access among the most underserved communities in and around Boston. According to the MBTA's latest Rider Census Report, 78% of respondents self-identify themselves as low-income riders.[1] The agency defines "low-income" as a household earning 80% or less based on their area's median income. Apart from the Mattapan Trolley, most of these riders use the bus, primarily to commute from home and work. The MBTA sets the bus fare at $1.70 each way, and $0.85 for those enrolled in applicable state assistance programs.[2] However, national studies have discovered that immigration concerns or administrative burdens mean that up to 30% of eligible households don't apply for these assistance programs, rendering them ineligible for reduced fares.[3] In addition, considering 61% of adults nationwide live paycheck-to-paycheck, and with Massachusetts being ranked as the 4th

[1]OPMI Data Blog, "The Newest MBTA System-Wide Passenger Survey Results Are Now Available," OPMI Data Blog, June 16, 2025, www.opmidatablog.com/latest-posts/the-newest-mbta-system-wide-passenger-survey-results-are-now-available

[2] Massachusetts Bay Transportation Authority, "Bus Fares," MBTA, accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/fares/bus-fares.

[3] Dulce Gonzalez and Hamutal Bernstein, One in Four Adults in Mixed-Status Families Did Not Participate in Safety Net Programs in 2022 Because of Green Card Concerns (Urban Institute, August 2023), www.urban.org/sites/default/files/2023-08/One%20in%20Four%20Adults%20in%20Mixed-Status%20Families%20Did%20Not%20Participate%20in%20Safety%20Net%20Programs%20in%202022%20Because%20of%20Green%20Card%20Concerns.pdf

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worst state to live in under these financial constraints, the $150 per month cost of transportation for a family of four has families struggling to travel freely.[4] [5] In the three municipalities in close proximity to Boston with the lowest median household income: Chelsea, Lynn, and Everett, up to 25% of residents ride public transit, compared to the state average of 15%.[6] All three cities incorporate infrastructure that promotes public transportation, such as dedicated bus lanes, transit priority signals, frequent service, and high-level stops to accommodate for disabled riders.[7]

In 2024, the advocacy group *Community Labor United* conducted a study on MBTA riders around Chelsea and Boston and discovered that 55.7% of respondents stated the fare is sometimes or often too high to afford.[8] In Chelsea, Lynn, and Everett, MBTA bus routes 111, 455, and 104 are the most utilized lines in each city. Around 10,000 riders on any given weekday take these routes, according to the T's statistics.[9] Instituting a fare-free bus pilot would mobilize the disadvantaged, largely working-class populations in these cities, while allowing all riders to reinvest the cost of fares into their savings or the local economy. Non-riders benefit as well, through less traffic, more available parking, and anticipated environmental benefits. In 2022, the City of Boston launched a fare-free pilot on three bus routes serving marginalized communities. Ridership increased by up to 23%, while ~20% of riders were first-time users, and 40% of riders

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[4] Emily Johnson and Taylor Johnson, "Massachusetts the 4th Worst State for Those Living Paycheck-to-Paycheck, Study Says," Boston Agent Magazine, May 12, 2017, bostonagentmagazine.com/2017/05/12/massaschusetts-4th-worst-state-living-paycheck-paycheck-study-says/.

[5] Elizabeth Guevara, "61% of Americans Live Paycheck-to-Paycheck — Even as Inflation Cools," CNBC, July 31, 2023, www.cnbc.com/2023/07/31/61percent-of-americans-live-paycheck-to-paycheck-even-as-inflation-cools.html.

[6] U.S. Census Bureau. "S1901: Income in the Past 12 Months, 2021 ACS 5-Year Estimates Subject Tables." data.census.gov. Accessed December 3, 2025. https://data.census.gov/table/ACSST5Y2021.S1901?q=Massachussets&t=Income+(Households,+Families,+Individuals)&g=040XX00US25$0600000&y=2021&d=ACS+5-Year+Estimates+Subject+Tables

[7] MBTA, "Better Bus Project," accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/projects/better-bus-project

[8] Community Labor United, Getting Around: Transportation and Affordability in Massachusetts (August 2024), www.massclu.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/clu_ptpg_gettingaroundr4v2.pdf

[9] MBTA / MassDOT, "Transit Priority Projects and GIS Data" [dataset], accessed December 3, 2025, https://mbta-massdot.opendata.arcgis.com/datasets/8daf4a33925a4df59183f860826d29ee/about.

saved money.[10] These outcomes indicate that fare-free service delivers measurable benefits for equity and affordability. Given the demographics and existing transportation-oriented infrastructure, extending fare-free pilots to the 111, 455, and 104 would directly benefit the low-income, bus-dependent communities the route serves.

The City of Boston's fare-free bus pilot provides valuable statistics supporting this thesis. In March 2022, the city made 3 bus lines free, the 23, 28, and 29, in the neighborhoods of Roxbury, Mattapan, and Dorchester. Similar to the cities mentioned above, these neighborhoods have lower average household income than the rest of Boston.[11] The City states that 200 trips (2%) were created that residents otherwise would not be able to take.[12] Doctor's appointments, tending to errands, and commuting to work and school didn't only become convenient because of free fares, they became possible. Families could travel easier knowing that everyone can ride along for free, and by October 2022, nearly half of all riders across these bus routes were saving up to $20.[13] Respondents noted that, "small daily savings add[ed] up quickly allowing significant benefit over the life of the program."[14] Hundreds of dollars in fares were being saved or used for expenses like food. The MBTA later reported that 19% of all riders on these lines were brand new.[15] Ridership as a whole along these lines increased by 23%, with buses also experiencing up to 23% faster dwell times at stops.[16] One of the sole critiques of the program was that the pilot wasn't expansive enough.[17] While environmental studies remain underway, it is expected that this program has helped reduce emissions as the MBTA reports that one in 20 vehicle trips are

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[10] City of Boston, "Fare Free Mid Program Report" (March 2023), www.boston.gov/sites/default/files/file/2023/03/Fare%20Free%20Mid%20Program%20Report.pdf.
[11] U.S. Census Bureau. "S1901: Income in the Past 12 Months, 2021 ACS 5-Year Estimates Subject Tables."
[12] City of Boston, "Fare Free Mid Program Report", 13.
[13] Ibid., 18.
[14] Ibid., 17.
[15] Ibid., 21.
[16] Ibid., 20, 24.
[17] Ibid., 28.

replaced by a bus ride.[18] The pilot was so successful that it was extended by Mayor Michelle Wu from its original 2 year timeline to a 4 year timeline, now running through 2026.[19] By removing the single barrier to mobility, the MBTA promotes economic growth, environmental protections, and access to services and places across the area. This pilot can then be used as a starting point to address further transit inequalities right outside the city limits to benefit working-class or student commuters into Boston.

The MBTA has historically underinvested in the 111 bus route in Chelsea. In a city of 39,460 where the median household income is $72,220 (~$41,900 less than state average) and the poverty rate lies over 20% (nearly 10% more than the state average), the route serves as a lifeline to many residents as the most economically feasible way to get from home to work or school.[20] [21] The 111 cuts directly through the middle of Chelsea, taking Broadway through the city's downtown and then the tolled Tobin Bridge over the Mystic River into Boston.[22] Although ridership has always been high, the route has a history of being inconsistent and unreliable. Curbed Boston reported in 2018 how the MBTA oversight board noted longstanding concerns regarding the route's frequent overcrowding and cancellations.[23] Then Chelsea City Manager Tom Ambrosino highlighted his frustration with the MBTA in 2021, stating, "if this were to happen in Newton or Wellesley, I certainly believe the problem would have gotten more attention."[24]

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[18] Ibid., 30.
[19] Boston, "Free Fares on Bus Routes 23, 28, and 29 Extended for Two More Years," press release, February 6, 2024, Boston.gov, https://www.boston.gov/news/free-fares-bus-routes-23-28-and-29-extended-two-more-years
[20] DataUSA, "Chelsea, MA," accessed December 3, 2025, https://datausa.io/profile/geo/chelsea-ma/.
[21] Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis, "MEHOINUSMAA646N," ALFRED (archival version of FRED), accessed December 3, 2025, https://alfred.stlouisfed.org/series?seid=MEHOINUSMAA646N.
[22] MBTA, "Schedule – 111 Line," MBTA, accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/schedules/111/line.
[23] Tom Acitelli, "Chelsea transportation issues to top agenda for MBTA oversight board," Curbed Boston, September 12, 2018, https://boston.curbed.com/2018/9/12/17851026/chelsea-111-bus.
[24] Bruce Mohl, "#111 Bus Now Getting Attention from the MBTA," CommonWealth Beacon, August 24, 2021, https://commonwealthbeacon.org/transportation/111-bus-getting-lots-of-attention-from-the-mbta/.

For years, riders paid fares on substandard service. While service has begun to improve, this program would reinforce confidence in riders since Boston has proven that fare-free lines benefitted from faster travel times without causing significant overcrowding. When ridership inevitably increases on the 111, the infrastructure is already there to support it. The CommonWealth Beacon reported in 2021 that the 111 has the most bus-only lanes out of every line in the system.[25] Today, every weekday from 4:30am to 2:00am, the 111 runs every 15 minutes or better. The MBTA should match recent investments into the 111 by eliminating fares not only to realign riders' costs with upgraded standards of service but to importantly expand travel flexibility in an underserved community. The Chelsea Record reported in 2024 that more than 50% of respondents in a survey of MBTA commuters said the cost of fares was too high to afford.[26] The transit advocacy site StreetsblogMA also reported in 2025 that 90% of 111 riders identify themselves as low-income.[27] There is a clear issue in transit equity because of affordability of fares. Half of all 111 riders struggle to meet the fare whilst nearly all riders work simply to make ends meet. A fare-free 111 bus could benefit service while significantly increasing transit mobility and ridership through one of the most vulnerable communities in the entire system.

Lynn presents a different problem, as service is inconsistent and historically underfunded. While the 111 and 104 buses run every 15 minutes for roughly 20 hours a day, the 455 is less

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[25] Ibid.
[26] Record Staff, "Alarming New Survey Reveals How High MBTA Fares Are Harming Riders," Chelsea Record, February 8, 2024, https://chelsearecord.com/2024/02/08/alarming-new-survey-reveals-how-high-mbta-fares-are-harming-riders/.
[27] Christian MilNeil, "Another Bus Lane Bites the Dust: Wu Administration Forces Chelsea, Charlestown Transit Riders to Wait In More Traffic," StreetsblogMASS, July 8, 2025, https://mass.streetsblog.org/2025/07/08/another-bus-lane-bites-the-dust-wu-administration-forces-chelsea-charlestown-transit-riders-to-wait-in-more-traffic.

than half as frequent through 18-19 hours a day.[28] Yet even through less service, the nearly 8,000 riders rely on this bus every weekday.[29] Lynn has a median household income of $74,715 and a 13.7% poverty rate, both statistics lower and higher than the state average respectively.[30] Lynn is larger than both Chelsea and Everett combined at a population of 100,905, making it the 9th largest city in the state.[31] However, the MBTA does not support Lynn as the major, low-income, transit-oriented city it should be. In 2023, *The Daily Live*, Lynn's newspaper, shared that Mayor Jared Nicholson said, "I do not think that the [MBTA] is properly serving Lynn residents," while State Senator Brendan Crighton described the transit situation as "frustrating."[32] Both leaders represent Lynn, a city served not only by buses but also rail. A single Commuter Rail stop in the city's central square shuttles passengers roughly every 30 to 60 minutes to and from North Station in Boston by train.[33] When the station closed in 2022 for a $74 million revitalization project, the T maintained service through shuttle buses to Swampscott station.[34] However, the closure reinforces a larger problem in the city that, even when operational, the Commuter Rail doesn't meet Lynn's needs.

Mayor Jared Nicholson reiterated this idea, "even if the Lynn Commuter Rail station was open, the city would still not be properly serviced by the MBTA."[35] The issue lies in the cost. A one way train ticket from Lynn, which is in Commuter Rail Zone 2, is $7.00, while its $3.50 reduced. This is 4 times higher than the bus fare. The Lynn City Council this year stated this

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[28] MBTA, "455 – Salem Depot / Wonderland Station," MBTA, accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/schedules/455/line.
[29] MBTA / MassDOT, "Transit Priority Projects and GIS Data."
[30] DataUSA, "Lynn, MA," accessed December 3, 2025, https://datausa.io/profile/geo/lynn-ma/.
[31] Ibid.
[32] Bruce Mohl, "What's Going On With the MBTA in Lynn?", Itemlive, July 6, 2023, https://itemlive.com/2023/07/06/whats-going-on-with-the-mbta-in-lynn/.
[33] MBTA, "CR-Newburyport Line Timetable," MBTA, accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/schedules/CR-Newburyport/timetable.
[34] Grecia White, "Lynn Commuter Rail Station Closes for Reconstruction Project," StreetsblogMASS, October 3, 2022, https://mass.streetsblog.org/2022/10/03/lynn-commuter-rail-station-closes-for-reconstruction-project.
[35] Mohl, "#111 Bus Now Getting Attention."

infrequent and expensive mode of transit is imposing, "unfair expenses on working families."[36] Residents have long been priced out of transit, as for a city with nearly identical income levels as Chelsea, 15% less of the population use the train or bus.[37] Even residents who qualify for reduced fares simply can't afford $116 a month for just the Commuter Rail. If they take just one more bus or train as well, their monthly expense can increase by about $50. In 2019, the Herald News forwarded a report by MassINC that found, "that two-thirds of households near the commuter rail station in Lynn are low-income, but that they represent only 7 percent of riders who board the train in that city. Those residents could be displaced."[38] The high cost and limited usage of the Commuter Rail is why nearly 8,000 boardings are made on the 455 every weekday, despite its poor service. The City of Lynn's published Transit Action Report of 2023 explains why more residents aren't taking local buses, explaining that, "the bus can sometimes feel like a transit mode of last resort, however, because of its relative infrequency and unreliability."[39] The MBTA could alleviate both financial and travel time concerns with a fare-free pilot. A trip to Downtown Boston through the Commuter Rail takes around 35-40 minutes, whereas using the 455 bus to the Blue Line through Wonderland Station could take 55-60 minutes. A fare-free pilot could speed up travel times on the 455 by reducing dwell times at stops, putting the time closer to a journey by rail.

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[36]Sophia Harris and Erell Renaudeau, "Lynn 8th Graders Tackle Transit," Itemlive, June 20, 2025, https://itemlive.com/2025/06/20/lynn-8th-graders-tackle-transit/

[37] Vision Lynn, "Vision Lynn Full Report."

[38] The Herald News, "Report: Gateway City Residents Priced Out of Commuter Rail," September 5, 2019, https://www.heraldnews.com/story/news/2019/09/05/report-gateway-city-residents-priced/3611393007/.

[39] Vision Lynn, "Vision Lynn Full Report" (May 30, 2023), accessed December 3, 2025, https://ehq-production-us-california.s3.us-west-1.amazonaws.com/f850526f78e5d8ceb930798dace5424869bc2e34/original/1685540617/72b6be1807fbc2257b863b4da3092ad8_Vision_Lynn_Full_Report_2023-05-30_Spreads-for-WEB_VIEW.pdf?X-Amz-Algorithm=AWS4-HMAC-SHA256&X-Amz-Credential=AKIA4KKNQAKIPIPQP5NM/20251202/us-west-1/s3/aws4_request&X-Amz-Date=20251202T211827Z&X-Amz-Expires=300&X-Amz-SignedHeaders=host&X-Amz-Signature=67e8fdba429817faf4e18c612bc6c274604b71ba0af86368c184be160da600d0.

Riders are already incentivized to travel by bus. They would benefit through the discounted bus to subway transfer, where they make up the difference between $1.70 or $0.85 and $2.40 or $1.20, discounting the total fare.[40] Such a credit system does not apply to the Commuter Rail. The 455 enjoys two bus lanes in Lynn, through the often congested Common Street and Western Ave corridors, which encourage more drivers to take the bus.[41] The MBTA could add more drivers and vehicles to the 455 to make up for an anticipated rise in ridership by simply advancing its Bus Network Redesign project. They are optimizing service in Lynn by reducing service on low-ridership routes, such as the 439 to Nahant, and sending those resources to more higher-ridership lines like the 455. The project realigns the 455 through the Lynnway and puts it at every 25 minutes during peak times.[42] Even without the redesign project, the MBTA could target service adjustments with existing routes, cutting or eliminating service on very low-ridership and redundant lines 424 (Eastern Avenue & Essex Street - Wonderland Station) and 456 (Salem Depot - Central Square, Lynn). These routes combine for 5.5% of the 455's ridership.[43] The MBTA has long neglected investment into Lynn's bus network, a sentiment echoed through its own leaders. A fare-free pilot on the 455 would offer immediate improvements to transportation equity in Lynn, strengthening the only mode of transit that the city's most vulnerable residents consistently use.

The 104 illustrates a different example of transit inequity, centered not on the lack of service but on the demographic makeup of the communities it serves. The MBTA recently redesigned the 104 bus route in Phase 1 of its Bus Network Redesign project. Originally, the route ran from Malden Center through Everett Square to Sullivan Square into Charlestown. Now,

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[40] MBTA, "Transfers," MBTA, accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/fares/transfers.
[41] MBTA, "Transit Priority Projects," MBTA, accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/projects/transit-priority-projects.
[42] MBTA, "Better Bus Project."
[43] MBTA / MassDOT, "Transit Priority Projects and GIS Data."

the latter terminus has been adjusted to Airport Station, sending the 104 through new developments on Second Street in Everett and later into Downtown Chelsea.[44] Regardless of the change, the 104 primarily serves Everett, a city of 49,236 where the median household income is $79,658 and the poverty rate is 15.4%.[45] The line notably services Glendale Towers, a 12-story Everett Housing Authority building for low-income elderly residents.[46] Residents of the towers and across Everett rely on the 104. The line was one of the strongest performing routes post-pandemic according to the Commonwealth Beacon, as by 2023 the 104 had 93% of its pre-pandemic ridership.[47] Today, nearly 9,000 riders use the bus every weekday.[48]

The City of Everett has continued to invest into making bus transit reliable and efficient for the route, installing new bus lanes on the new Second Street portion of the route while maintaining existing ones through Everett Square.[49] The MBTA has also invested in the route, running it every 15 minutes from 5am to 1am, sharing the same headways as the 111.[50] A BU MetroBridge report on transportation in Everett found that 24% of residents use MBTA buses to commute, due to the city's largely transit oriented demographics.[51] Everett notably has higher concentrations of foreign-born individuals, people with disabilities, and young professionals.[52] The 104 line itself, as StreetsblogMA reports, serves 64% non-white people in a mile radius of

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[44] MBTA, "Bus Network Redesign – Phase 1 Service Changes," MBTA, accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/projects/bus-network-redesign/phase-1-service-changes.
[45] DataUSA, "Everett, MA," accessed December 3, 2025, https://datausa.io/profile/geo/everett-ma/.
[46] Everett Housing Authority, "Public Housing," accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.everetthousingauthority.org/public.aspx.
[47] Bruce Mohl, "Some MBTA Bus Routes Back to Pre-COVID Ridership Levels," CommonWealth Beacon, September 22, 2023, https://commonwealthbeacon.org/transportation/some-mbta-bus-routes-back-to-pre-covid-ridership-levels
[48] MBTA / MassDOT, "Transit Priority Projects and GIS Data."
[49] Meghan Volcy, "Route Review: Riding the New Frequent-Service 104 from Malden," StreetsblogMASS, December 20, 2024, https://mass.streetsblog.org/2024/12/20/route-review-riding-the-new-frequent-service-104-from-malden
[50] MBTA, "Schedule – 104 Line," MBTA, accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.mbta.com/schedules/104/line.
[51] MetroBridge, Everett BU-MetroBridge Report: Sustainable Transit (Boston University, 2019), accessed December 3, 2025, https://www.bu.edu/ioc/files/2019/08/Everett_BU-MetroBridge-Report_Sustainable-Transit-1.pdf.
[52] Ibid.

its stops.[53] Furthermore, 16% of residents within this radius live under the poverty line.[54] While the bus runs along an ideal corridor for those reliant on service, these same groups remain the least able to absorb the costs of transportation. Everett, along with Chelsea and Lynn, is considered a "gateway city" by the MassINC Policy Center. In total, 26 gateway cities house 43% of the state's low-income residents while only encompassing 27% of the population.[55] Decades of disinvestment have led these marginalized communities to disproportionately rely on public transportation. Routes like the 104 serve not as convenient options for transit, but essential mobility corridors. Families that ride these buses are already struggling significantly more than most Massachusetts residents with income inequality. A fare-free 104 would directly address mobility barriers, building on recent city and MBTA investments into the route, further allowing flexible transit options for the most marginalized communities.

Successes and concerns from Boston's fare-free bus pilot were discussed in the MBTA's 2025 report on the program. The Authority describes how broad fare-free programs face significant challenges. They acknowledge that, "the systemwide provision of fare-free bus services has potential to deliver positive impacts for MBTA riders," but also state, "the costs associated with such a policy are significant, currently estimated at between $72 and $121 million per year. The MBTA does not have the funding to bear these costs in its current fiscal situation."[56] Third-party analyses on Boston's fare-free pilot have widely established a broad fare-free MBTA bus initiative as the next step. Northeastern's 2019 evaluation of the pilot states this exactly, concluding, "this analysis will provide the foundation to expand the fare-free pilot

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[53] Meghan Volcy, "Route Review: Riding the New Frequent-Service 104 from Malden."
[54] Ibid.
[55] MassINC Policy Center, 2024 Gateway Cities Housing Monitor (Boston: MassINC Policy Center, 2024), https://massinc.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/11/2024-Gateway-Cities-Housing-Monitor.pdf.
[56] Massachusetts House of Representatives, FY 2025 MBTA Fare-Free Bus Report, H.D. 4638 (2024), https://malegislature.gov/Bills/194/HD4638.pdf

across the MBTA's entire service area."[57] Even State Representative Mike Connolly formally introduced legislation, "implementing free public transit."[58] However, all these broad fare-free ideas face significant financial constraints and political challenges, as shown by the lack of progress these proposals have made. It is clear that the state legislature and the MBTA is incapable of having an entirely fare-free bus system being the immediate successor to the Boston pilot. However, the positive effects of the pilot should not be underestimated, and therefore can be used to further direct proposals to address other areas of overwhelming transit inequality. Gradual advancements into fare-free transit are more cost-effective and politically feasible than the immediate elimination of all bus fares around Boston.

The MBTA's report importantly states concerns with individual fare-free pilots as well, considering them "unsustainable and not recommended."[59] However, the authority describes these constraints in the event that the program is time-limited and the MBTA is responsible for covering the lost revenue. The agency's chief of policy stresses concerns about reintroducing fares, rider confusion, and broader geographic concerns about transit equity should only a select amount of lines continue to become fare-free. However, none of these issues arise with this specific plan. This proposal suggests that the state funds this pilot, mirroring fare-free transportation investments led by Governor Healey, importantly at a much more cost-effective price point than the elimination of all MBTA bus fares.[60] This pilot can feasibly exist because of

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[57] Northeastern University Policy School, Evaluation of a Fare-Free Bus for Boston (Boston: Northeastern University, 2021), https://cssh.northeastern.edu/policyschool/wp-content/uploads/sites/2/2021/07/Evaluation-of-a-Fare-Free-Bus-for-Boston.pdf

[58] H. 3637, *An Act implementing free public transit*, 194th General Court (Mass. 2025), https://malegislature.gov/Bills/194/H3637.pdf

[59] Massachusetts House of Representatives, FY 2025 MBTA Fare-Free Bus Report, H.D. 4638 (2024).

[60] Massachusetts Department of Transportation, "Healey-Driscoll Administration Announces Fare Free Regional Transit Across State," press release, October 24, 2024, https://www.mass.gov/news/healey-driscoll-administration-announces-fare-free-regional-transit-across-state

the Governor's precedent of funding and sustaining fare-free programs. Furthermore, the MBTA very likely will not face rider confusion as they already use a hybrid fare system, whether through the Boston fare-free pilot routes or the Commuter Rail where ticket prices vary from town to town. Users are already accustomed to learning and understanding different prices, including when fares are free. Lastly, should the state fund a fare-free pilot, concerns of geographic inequity do not arise, as municipalities that may be low-income and transit-oriented but cannot afford these programs will not foot the cost for them. Equity requires a proportional, directed approach rather than a blanket policy. This is especially relevant when such a policy is politically challenging and financially demanding. Therefore, a state-funded fare-free pilot on the 111, 455, and 104 enhances equity by applying financial relief to residents where the burden is highest. The MBTA has stressed that the Boston pilot expressed substantial benefits to disadvantaged communities, and given the Healey administration's broader transportation goals, the next step toward meaningful transportation equity is to invest in the corridors that face the highest barriers to access.

With these routes demonstrating both urgent need and effective impact in becoming fare-free, the remaining task is determining how to fund the program. Estimates from Boston's fare-free bus pilot put the cost of covering the fares of each route at $2.67M for every 2 years. Given this proposal also targets three key bus routes, this entire proposal should cost the same, around $8M. The Commonwealth of Massachusetts can fund this program in various different ways. One way would be to replicate funding from the fare-free bus pilot program in Boston which used federal funding, however given the current political climate this option seems unlikely. The state could raise the Millionaire's Tax by 0.003%, but even such a small increase would reopen debates and require a constitutional amendment. The most feasible and practical

funding source would be to use a portion of interest earned on the state's rainy day savings fund. As recently as September 2024, Governor Healey announced that she would use the interest from the state's nearly $8B in savings to match parts of federal grants for projects, explicitly including transportation.[61] Specifically, up to $50M in grants can be allocated. While this current legislation requires a federal program to be implemented first, the initiative outlines the Governor's willingness to use the interest funds to reinvest in transportation programs across the state. An amendment to the law, not the constitution, could allow for operational spending and send a small portion of the money earned on interest payments to the MBTA to reimburse lost fares on this pilot. The savings balance would never be used, while the pilot can be sustainably funded and expanded upon for the foreseeable future, bringing transit equality to the most vulnerable of populations. The legislature and Governor have already moved to finance fare-free transit, as in October 2024 the Governor announced $30M in grants to fund 13 regional transit agencies in the state, stretching from Worcester to Fall River.[62] Local advocacy through lobbying lawmakers and city officials could build momentum for this project and begin feasibility studies. The legislature has proven, as a whole, that they are willing to invest in transit programs even if it does not directly benefit their localities. This pilot program remains feasible and practical, from both a financial and operational standpoint. The expansion of fare-free transit through low-income communities serviced by the MBTA along lines 111, 455, and 104 will increase mobility, economic growth, and provide environmental benefits to all residents.

Equitable transportation is vital to strengthening communities as it provides the basis for everyone to move freely within their own cities. The Commonwealth of Massachusetts should

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[61] Massachusetts Office of the Governor, "Governor Healey Signs Legislation Unlocking Millions to Compete for Federal Funding," September 24, 2024, https://www.mass.gov/news/governor-healey-signs-legislation-unlocking-millions-to-compete-for-federal-funding

[62] Massachusetts Department of Transportation, "Healey-Driscoll Administration Announces Fare Free Regional Transit."

fund and expand this successful pilot program approach to the 3 most underserved MBTA communities outside of Boston: Chelsea, Lynn, and Everett. The most used lines in each city, being the 111, 104, and 455 respectively, should be fare-free. Taking data from the MBTA's pilot, this proposal can see riders save a total of 1,300,000 minutes of their commute while reinvesting $2,300,000 into the local economy.[63] Ridership can increase by as much as 23%, while cities experience less traffic, saving fuel and road maintenance costs, businesses enjoy more customers through residents saving fare money and more accessible parking spots, and everyone benefits from healthier environmental conditions and a more accessible community.[64] Targeted, fare-free pilots are the next logical step in a cost-effective and data-driven approach to relieve transit inequity in some of the state's most marginalized cities. The Commonwealth should view this pilot not as an investment in bus lines, but as an investment in the people they serve. The immigrant, working-class, disabled, student, or young professional residents that run these cities should be able to go to work, school, the store, or the doctor without worrying about the cost of a public service. At the same time, the non-public transportation riding populations of these cities enjoy more breathable air, less dangerous roads thanks to lower car volumes, and more accessible parking. Every citizen of these cities can enjoy the benefits of a fare-free transportation system, and the Commonwealth can further the advancement of people living in Greater Boston to encompass a healthy and well-connected population, guiding the rest of the nation in transit equality and urban life.

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[63] City of Boston, Fare Free Mid Program Report.
[64] Ibid., 20.

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